Reading

When I returned home from the outset of my second voyage to England, my brother Jyotirindra and sister-in-law were living in a river-side villa at Chandernagore, and there I went to stay with them.

The Ganges again! Again those **ineffable** days and nights, **languid** with joy, sad with longing, attuned to the **plaintive** babbling of the river along the cool shade of its wooded banks. This Bengal sky-full of light, this south breeze, this flow of the river, this right royal laziness, this broad leisure stretching from horizon to horizon and from green earth to blue sky, all these were to me as food and drink to the hungry and thirsty. Here it felt indeed like home, and in these I recognised the **ministrations** of a Mother.

That was not so very long ago, and yet time has **wrought** many changes. Our little riverside nests, **clustering** under their surrounding greenery, have been replaced by mills which now, dragon-like, everywhere rear their hissing heads, **belching** forth black smoke. In the midday glare of modern life even our hours of mental siesta have been narrowed down to the lowest limit, and hydra-headed unrest has invaded every department of life. Maybe, this is for the better, but I, for one, cannot account it wholly to the good.

These lovely days of mine at the riverside passed by like so many dedicated lotus blossoms floating down the sacred stream. Some rainy afternoons I spent in a **veritable** frenzy, singing away old Vaishnava songs to my own tunes, accompanying myself on a harmonium. On other afternoons, we would drift along in a boat, my brother Jyotirindra accompanying my singing with his violin. And as, beginning with the Puravi, we went on varying the mode of our music with the declining day, we saw, on reaching the Behaga, the western sky close the doors of its factory of golden toys, and the moon on the east rise over the fringe of trees.



8th_english_4 to 6.indd 93 16-12-2022 14:25:15